

Pixar's Rule #4 and StoryDogs

A practical guide for teachers and librarians • K–6

Pixar's Rule #4 offers a simple way to connect story events. A character has an ordinary life. Something changes, one problem leads to another, and the character reaches a deciding moment. StoryDogs turns that pattern into seven child-friendly steps.

The six-line version of Rule #4

"Once upon a time there was _____. Every day, _____. One day _____. Because of that, _____. Because of that, _____. Until finally _____."

StoryDogs adds "Ever since then, _____" to show what changes afterward. That seventh line is a StoryDogs extension to the six-line rule above; it is not part of that quoted rule. [1]

Read across: question → story starter → two answers

StoryDogs step and question	Matching story starter	Keep the two answers separate
WHO? Who is the story about?	Once upon a time there was...	Character + something they struggle with or fear.
LIFE / WANT What is ordinary life like, and what do they want?	Every day...	Ordinary life + a wish and why it matters.
UH-OH! What upsets that life?	One day...	The change + what the character decides to do.
TROUBLE What problem follows?	Because of that...	An obstacle + an attempt that causes the next problem.
WORSE! What makes it harder?	Because of that...	The harder situation + what the character could lose.
CLIMAX What do they do at the biggest moment?	Until finally...	The biggest challenge + a choice and its result.
CHANGE / AFTER! How are they different afterward?	Ever since then... StoryDogs extension	What they learn or change + life at the end.

One row is one story beat. Its two answers may become one sentence or two short sentences. They do not become two separate steps.

Teach the connections, then let them write

What you can say

"We're going to build a story one piece at a time. First we'll meet someone and find out what they want. Then something will go wrong. We'll ask what happens because of it, and what our character chooses to do. At the end, we'll see what's different."

The important word is "because"

"And then" tells us what comes next. "Because of that" asks why it happens. When the middle feels random, ask: "Did our character's last action help cause this problem?" Silly ideas are welcome. Give them a connection.

For example: Bea sprinkles flour to stop her runaway cake cart. The wheels skid on the flour, sending the cart toward the duck pond. The second problem grows out of her first attempt. A surprise spaceship would need a reason to enter this particular cake emergency.

Turn the answers into a story line

Separate StoryDogs answers	Matching narrative
WHO? Character: Bea is a bear baker. Struggle: She hates asking for help.	Once upon a time there was Bea, a bear baker who hated asking for help.
CLIMAX Challenge: Ask for help before the cake falls. Choice/result: Call friends; they catch it in a blanket.	Until finally Bea asked for help. Her friends caught the cake in a blanket.

Keep the child's meaning. Change verb tense or join sentences for readability, but ask the child about missing details instead of inventing them. In a student report, leave a blank response incomplete or omit it cleanly.

Help the ending earn its place

The climax is the character's important action or choice, not simply the loudest event. CHANGE shows its effect: Bea now invites friends to bake with her. Children can show a small change in confidence, understanding, a relationship, or a habit. They do not need to announce a moral.

Adapt it to your group

K-2: tell it aloud, draw, act it out, or dictate to an adult scribe. Grades 3-6: use the outline to write a comic, short story, or scene. Add dialogue and details in the draft. The starters are practice supports; finished stories do not have to keep them. A messy first draft is useful.

Optional Grades 4-6 terms: WHO = protagonist; TROUBLE = conflict; TROUBLE and WORSE = rising action; CLIMAX = climax; CHANGE = resolution.

Attribution and further reading

The name "Pixar's Rule #4" refers to a tip in the storytelling list shared by Pixar story artist Emma Coats. The underlying Story Spine predates that list. Kenn Adams describes his original version, which also includes an "ever since then" ending. "StoryDogs extension" identifies our addition to the six-line version, not ownership of the closing phrase. [1-2]

[1] [Rule #4 wording and background • Aerogramme Writers' Studio](#)

[2] [Back to the Story Spine • Kenn Adams, guest author](#)